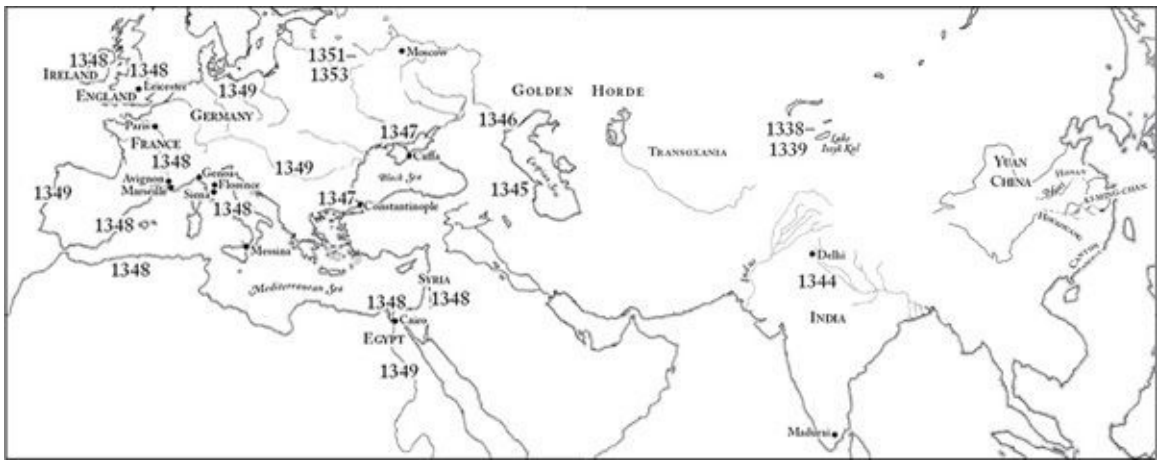
waiting among the dead for death to come, have committed to writing what I have truly heard . . . I leave parchment for continuing the work, in case anyone should still be alive in the future." Beneath these last words is added, in the handwriting of another, "Here, it seems, the author died."[11]



72.1 The Spread of the Plague

Between October of 1348 and February of 1349, a hundred thousand Egyptians died in Cairo alone. "Cairo became an empty desert," wrote the Arab chronicler Maqrizi, "and there was no one to be seen in the streets. A man could go from the Zuwayla Gate to the Bab al-Nasr without encountering another soul. . . . Corpses lay piled along the public way, burial trains jostled one another, and the dead were carried to their graves amidst commotion."[12]

"No one controls anything and they do not even ring the church bells anymore," wrote Agnolo di Tura, from the Tuscan town of Siena. "Giant pits are being excavated for the multitudes of the dead and the hundreds that die every night. And I . . . have buried five of my sons with my own hands. . . . Everyone believes it is the end of the world."[13]

AND THEN THE DYING, finally, began to slow.

By the middle of 1350, plague deaths in England and Europe had thinned to a tiny trickle. The epidemic circled back around through the land of the Rus', where it persisted until 1353, killing the Grand Duke of Moscow and all seven of his children. And it was never again entirely absent; all over the known world, plague outbreaks would erupt again and again.[14]

The survivors found themselves facing newly emptied countrysides, deserted villages, waste fields. "In the following winter there was such a lack of workers," Henry Knighton complained, ". . . that there had hardly ever been such a shortage before." In England, prices of essentials had tripled or